

Magnetism

Magnets exert a force called magnetism, which can attract certain objects—especially those containing iron.



This magnet has attracted a clump of steel paper clips because steel has an iron content.

Attract or repel?

Magnets attract materials containing iron, and they can also attract other magnets. Two magnets can also push apart, or “repel.”

Opposite poles of a magnet attract each other.

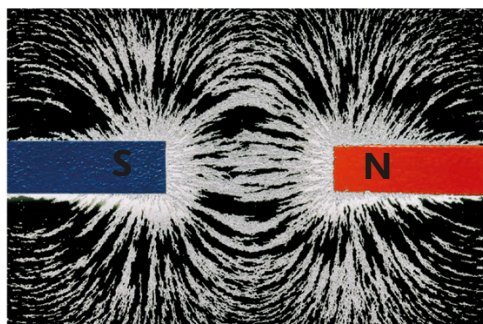


Magnet rules

The ends of a magnet are called the north and south poles. Opposite poles attract each other. Similar poles repel each other.



Similar poles of a magnet repel each other.



Iron filings show the magnetic field between the two magnets.

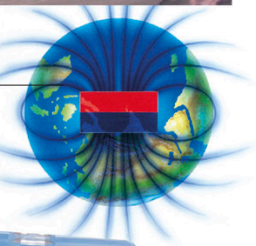


The Northern Lights are partly due to magnetic forces in our atmosphere.

Lights in the sky

Amazing lights are caused when particles in the solar wind (streaming from the Sun) travel into the atmosphere along force lines in the Earth’s magnetic field.

The Earth has a magnetic field.



The Earth as a magnet

The Earth behaves as if there is a giant invisible magnet between the North and South poles. That’s why we can use a compass to find our way.

